



OTT

LAYING DOWN THE LAW

SHOWS LIKE GUILTY MINDS *ARE PROOF THAT OTT PLATFORMS HAVE FOUND A WINNER IN GRITTY LEGAL DRAMAS*

Shefali Bhushan is no stranger to the legal profession. The filmmaker's family boasts of several illustrious members in the legal fraternity (legal luminary Shanti Bhushan is her father, public interest lawyer Prashant Bhushan her brother) so developing the Amazon Prime courtroom drama *Guilty Minds* came easy. Her writing team comprised Manav Bhushan, a biomedical engineer with a law degree, and Deeksha Gujral, a human rights lawyer. They made sure the "line of arguments and sections quoted" were accurate. Shefali also did a tour of the courts with co-director Jayant Digambar Samalkar, her director of photography and the production designer to ensure they got the ambience right.

Given this insistence on accuracy, it's no surprise that *Guilty Minds,* released late last month, has drawn much praise for its authentic depiction of judicial proceedings. "Of course, there are places where you can't be completely true, so you take creative liberties," says Shefali.

While the success of *Guilty Minds* hinges on its own merit, it is also an indicator of a larger trend—legal dramas are taking off on OTT. Almost every major platform has a show in the genre. SonyLIV has released two seasons of *Your Honor* (2020-), an adaptation of an Israeli series, in which Jimmy Sheirgill plays a judge whose principles are put to the test when his son is involved in a hit-and-run. One of Disney+ Hotstar's biggest hits is *Criminal Justice* (2019-), another international adaptation created by Applause Entertainment featuring Pankaj Tripathi and Anupriya Goenka as lawyers fighting the good fight. ALT-Balaji's *The Verdict—State vs Nanavati* (2019-) and Voot's *Illegal–Justice, Out of Order* (2020-21) also dabbled in the genre. The third season of *Criminal Justice* is in the works and it is likely that *Guilty Minds,* too, will get a second season.

The third season of **CRIMINAL JUSTICE** is in the works and it now looks like **GUILTY MINDS,** too, will get a second season

For Shefali, it was key that the cases in *Guilty Minds* "raise questions" and "start a conversation" on topics such as the effect of violent video games on teens, sexism at the workplace, plagiarism in music industry etc. The show also looks at the workings of a family-run firm and Shefali throws in a love triangle to add to the